

PROMPT: Fable writes the five of them as people, before the spine

Updated 2026-08-29 against premise v6, after Trish's agreed read of v5.

Paste the block below. Attach nothing. **Everything Fable needs is in the brief, deliberately** — a spine would tell it who the killer is, and it must not know. △ When the cupboard's contents are decided, they stay OUT of this brief and out of any follow-up to Fable, for the same reason.

★ **This is a change to the pipeline.** Until now Fable only saw a spine after it was locked, which meant characters were built as functions by Claude and inherited. The sharpest craft note of the week was that victims need *lives more specific than illnesses and houses*. This is the fix.

PASTE FROM HERE

You are writing the people at the centre of Episode One of **Ally Quinn: True Crime Merge**, a mobile game framed as a true-crime podcast in the fictional coastal city of Havenbay.

There is no script yet and no plot document, on purpose. Everything that has failed on this project failed because people were built as slots and then somebody tried to make them human afterwards. **You are going first this time.**

The situation, and it is all you need

A woman was murdered. She was found at the foot of her own stairs, and the injury that killed her is exactly what a fall leaves. **Her death was recorded as an accident, so nobody investigated.**

She had four close friends. Some months before she died she was frightened, because she had worked out that one of those four was planning to kill her. What she had fell short of proof, and using it meant accusing somebody she loved, so she hid it instead. She made an arrangement so that **after her death, all four of them would receive a key to where she had hidden it.**

The keys went out. **By the time they got there, it was gone.** One of them had been first.

So four people who loved her now know, with certainty, that one of the other three took it. **They cannot prove anything and they cannot go to the police with an empty cupboard.** They have started meeting anyway, because working out which of them it is has become the only thing any of them can do.

★ What we need from you: the five of them, as people

The dead woman, and the four friends.

Not profiles. Not bullet points. Not a spec sheet. A short passage each, written the way you would write them if you already knew them. Two hundred words each at the outside. **We want to be able to hear them in a room.**

For each of the four, we specifically need:

- **How they knew her**, and how long, and what the friendship actually consisted of. Not "they were close." What they did together on an ordinary Tuesday.
- ★ **What each of them had of her that the others did not.** This is the most important thing in the brief. Real friendships are asymmetric and everybody gets a different version of a person. One of them knew about the money. One of them met her mother. One of them she rang at four in the morning once and they have never spoken about it since. **Only together do these four see her whole, and that is the engine of the episode.**
- **What they are like when they are frightened**, because all four of them are.
- **What each of them thinks of the other three**, including who they have never liked.

For **her**: she is dead before the first line and everything depends on the audience caring. **Give her routine, competence, humour, friction, work, appetite, a bad habit.** She is not compelling because we say she was kind. **She becomes present through what was interrupted.**

★★ THE ONE HARD RULE: YOU DO NOT KNOW WHICH ONE DID IT

We have not told you, and we are not going to.

Write all four as innocent people. Write them so that **any one of the four could be the one**, and so that a reader who is told the answer afterwards goes back and finds it was always sitting there. **We will choose which one after we read them.**

If you decide privately who it is and write him accordingly, we will be able to tell, and so will every reader. **Four people who all had a reason and all loved her is the whole episode.**

One consequence to build in: two of these four will survive the episode and two will not, and **the two who survive are the two who were furthest from working it out.** So make them differently sharp, in different ways. **Do not make one of them obviously the clever one** — make it genuinely arguable which of them would get there first.

Constraints

Names. Invent them. A group of friends who found each other somewhere specific. **Do not use:** Ally, Del, Gerald, Arthur, Nova, Mo, Frankie, Dot, Priya, Cortez, Drake, Benji, Vex, Rourke, Hart, Voss, Kroll, Rosa, Kerry, Dean, Leah, Maureen, Colin, Winnie, Marion, Edith, Gordon, Josie, Yardley, Kessler, Fisk.

Ages: none of them elderly, none of them a child. Ruled for the pilot.

No em dashes anywhere. Comma, full stop, colon or a middle dot. Hard project rule.

Nothing gore-led, and no detail that exists only for effect. Detail that changes understanding may be unflinching.

Voice. A reader has twice said Ally's phrasing reads as strange, and that if the noir styling was causing it the styling had to go. **That applies here too.** Grounded and contemporary. These are five people in a coastal city, not five people in a film.

What we are not asking for

No plot, no timeline, no investigation, no clues, no scenes, no dialogue beyond what a person would obviously say. **No theory about who did it.** Whether any of this can be built is somebody else's job.

Deliverable

Five passages. Then, in one line each and nothing more:

- **Which two of them you would put in a room together for the whole episode**, and why those two.
- **Anything you invented that you would fight to keep.**

PASTE TO HERE
